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Jerry Coker

Saxophonist and jazz educator Jerry Coker is a pioneer in the field of jazz education. After gigs with Woody Herman and Stan Kenton, Jerry turned his attention to the need for a resource for aspiring jazz improvisers. His books span decades and topics, including Improvising Jazz (1964) and the Jazz Age in America (2020).

Jerry was interviewed via Zoom on August 18, 2023 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive. Jerry's son, Curt Coker, assisted in the interview.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I'm very pleased to have Jerry Coker with me today for the Fillius Jazz Archive. Welcome, sir.

JC: Well thank you.

MR: It's a pleasure and I'm going to introduce you as a saxophonist and a music teacher and one of our first pioneers of jazz education. Thank you for that legacy you've created. And you noticed right away the — you said, "I recognize that book, I had placed some books behind me that you wrote, including this one.

JC: Oh yeah.

MR: Which I may quote from today. Say that again?

JC: It's ancient and dated by now.

MR: That's true, but it holds up very well. And I was looking at one thing that you had written, it said, "the memory retains everything that has ever been heard." And I play for senior citizens on occasion, which I am now a part of, and it's amazing that you can play tunes that go way back when people were children and they can remember them. Do you remember any songs from your childhood that really stood out and sort of set you on a path in music?

CC: Do you remember any songs or tunes from your childhood that set you on your path?

JC: A few. A few. Because before I started playing I was listening to the Hit Parade and that sort of thing so I was exposed to what was going on. But I also, I must tell you that my father was a jazz musician and so was my mother. And they had a huge record collection so that I had become so familiar with it from the time I was very young it was going on around me. So yeah there was an advantage.

MR: Definitely. Did you start to be curious about what your mother and father were doing with this improvisation thing? Like how are they making up that music?

JC: How were they making the music?

MR: Well if you were watching them play, either at home or perhaps you saw them on a gig and they started playing their instruments and they weren't reading the music, if they were making it up, did you wonder how that happened and were curious about it?

CC: Were you curious how your parents were able to improvise?

JC: By experience, playing with others, listening carefully to both, and good ears and a good memory for music. So yeah, they learned what they learned mostly from listening. There were no places to study. You know there were no teachers, that was a whole new thing.

MR: What were — do you recall any of the songs they would have played back then? If they were jazz musicians were they playing Duke Ellington and the standards?

JC: Were they playing standards?

MR: Yes. And perhaps like "Take the A Train," that kind of music?

JC: Yeah. Right. And my father played — continued to play a long time after his youth. So it was close to it and so when my brother and I grew up and we started playing our records, he got interested in what records we were listening to, and he kept up with us very well and so did my mother. They came to hear us play when they could.

MR: What did your father or mother think of Charlie Parker?

JC: What?

MR: What did they think of Charlie Parker and Dizzy?

JC: They reacted to it very much the same way we did. At first it was a little too much, you wondered what he was doing and that sort of thing. But over time they got used to that and so I couldn't surprise them anymore. If I played something from somebody more remote, like Lee Konitz or someone, they still had the ability to shift into that gear to hear what he was doing. So it was — it was totally open with how we talked about jazz. We didn't have to atone for any shortcomings by the other person.

MR: That's really fortunate for you. I know my father would come up to my room when I was playing the latest John Coltrane record and he would just open the door like with this puzzled look on his face. He did not enjoy it.

JC: Oh that's too bad.

MR: Yes. But he was not a musician but he was very encouraging to my career. Were your parents happy that you were going to pursue music as a career?

JC: Yes I think they were. They were really proud of it. And my older brother, he's 3-1/2 years older than I was, sort of paved the way because I was always in his shadow for a long time now. He was a very good player and he was older, he had a little more experience and so, you know, it was helpful to have him around. So I had parents who appreciated what I was doing, and an older brother who was looking after me to make sure I was exposed to the right things and could answer questions when I had them. Eventually it turned around to where he would ask me things, you know, but it took a

while. Because he was a smart person. He had a very high grade average in school and in universitites.

MR: Now when you went to college did you go as a — to study music because there was no jazz to be studied, but did you go then as a classical musician?

JC: Well I was prepared to be a classical musician if necessary. And the courses, well for one thing I had private teachers who taught jazz that were good players. Junie Ferrell for example. I studied with him for quite some time. And it was a tremendous help. You know it kept me on track.

MR: The Woody Herman Orchestra, I almost feel like I missed my era because I always had fantasies of playing in the swing bands, which you did. What did you have to do to get into the Woody Herman Orchestra? Did you have to audition? Did you have to audition?

JC: Have what?

MR: Did you have to audition for Woody Herman?

JC: Oh yeah. I usually like to — see when musicians would come to nearby places to be for a week or two, a lake resort, that kind of thing, I was always familiar with the lake resort, having taught, played there a lot. So it gave me a chance to see the musicians even during the day, like if they were rehearsing or at the very least I could certainly find a lot of individuals to talk to that were a help. When it was time for me to audition for Woody I had already gotten to know his book just from listening. The audition took place right there where I was in my home territory. And I was used to doing that, coming along after my father, who was an improvising player and as people listened to him, I listened to him, he listened to me and I mean we were all very close that way. It was a wonderful way to be coming into the music scene. And my older brother, 3-1/2 years older, who eventually played with Wes Montgomery and was a very good pianist. He was able to help me a lot too, because he would get to places before I did. He was 3-1/2 years older and so he did everything before I did.

MR: That's terrific. So you were in your early 20s and you're going to go on the road with the Woody Herman Orchestra. I mean this is an obvious question, but were you excited about it?

CC: Were you excited about going on the road with Woody Herman?

JC: Yes, yes I was. I wouldn't say it was as stark as it was for others because my father was a professional musician, my mother was a professional musician, my older brother, and so it was just another band, you know it was another playing experience. It wasn't the same romantic thing about it. A little bit of it of course, because of the history of it. I'd heard his band so much, on record and in live as well. And so it was a realistic kind of thing for me. I wasn't overwhelmed with the opportunity, you know?

MR: Yes.

JC: I expected it to happen sooner or later.

MR: Do you recall what your salary was when you first went on the road with them?

JC: My what?

MR: Your salary? How much did you get paid?

JC: Oh wow. I really can't remember. It seems like it was around 90 dollars a week or something. I'm guessing but I think that's about where it was. We didn't do it for the money, you know?

MR: That's true. Did you have to pay your own hotel and all that kind of thing?

JC: Oh yeah. We'd just think of it that part of your salary was going to come out to pay for your room & board so to speak.

MR: So who were in the saxophone section back then? Was it Herbie Steward, and was Zoot Sims there during your stay?

JC: Was it what?

MR: The other saxophone players that you were playing with.

JC: Oh well none of them were like Stan Getz or Zoot Sims, you know big names. But they were pretty good players. I was spoiled because my father introduced me to so many musicians and I heard him play all the time, he was always a soloist and you could catch him on the radio playing with bands and things. And so it was natural for me. It wasn't an overwhelming kind of pressure. I didn't feel that way about it. In fact if anything I knew the weaknesses, musical weaknesses of Woody Herman's band before I ever joined it or played with it. I knew what they were struggling with. I could tell how deep the musicians were thinking and how, you know, that sort of thing. So it was not as different an experience as it would be for most people. Plus the fact that my father had heard him play and rehearse with bands and my mother, they both worked a lot, played a lot. So it was a good upbringing. I was ready for that. So Woody Herman's band were just another bunch of musicians. It wasn't like glory.

MR: I see. That's an interesting attitude. Did the musicians have nicknames?

JC: Has the music changed?

MR: No. Did the musicians in Woody Herman's band have nicknames?

CC: Did the musicians in Woody's band have nicknames?

JC: Six names?

MR: The reason I'm asking this is because I read that your nickname, Jerry, was "The Fog."

CC: Did the other musicians have nicknames?

JC: Nicknames?

MR: Yes.

JC: Some of them did.

MR: What about you? Did you have a nickname in the band?

JC: They called me "Junior Jazz."

MR: "Junior Jazz."

JC: My mother and father had already been there, and my older brother was always ahead of me you know. I was the youngest one, so I was "Junior Jazz."

MR: Well I read a story in a book about Woody Herman. And the band was in Seattle and that you forget that they had a gig one night, and they left without you. Do you remember that?

JC: No.

MR: Okay. Well I'm going to remind you because the story was you forgot they had a gig and you found a bus to get there and you got there an hour and a half late and you thought everybody was going to be mad but instead they had taken bets on when you were going to arrive.

JC: Oh right. Yeah I remember that. I don't remember who won, I know it wasn't me.

MR: Was Woody mad at you for being late?

JC: I beg your pardon?

MR: Was Woody mad at you for being late?

JC: He was like a father to me. I was still awfully young and he took a liking to me and so he was understanding, you know? It was different than it was for the other guys in the band. For them they were liable to lose their jobs over things like that you know. But Woody was very fatherly to me.

MR: What did you learn from the other musicians in the band who were mostly — you used a term, "pure professionalism" in one of your books describing those musicians, that they were mostly self-taught. And I wonder —

CC: Mostly self-taught.

JC: Oh yeah, right. No I think it's been very recent that musicians learn to do what they learn now in a college or a university. It wasn't like that, you know, at the time I was growing up. And it certainly wasn't like that at the time the other players in the band were growing up, because they were all older than I was. But they had to all learn the same way, going and hearing things and sitting in and that sort of thing. But it was a very different experience whereas for me I already knew the inside feelings of a jazz musician: what they thought about, what they needed to know, what they practiced. Because all I had to do was watch my brother or my father or my mother. They all practiced and practiced a lot.

MR: It's almost like you were starting to work on your books back then by the fact that you knew this material and the other players really did not.

JC: That's right. That's correct. I was working very hard on musical materials and I grabbed the opportunity to, you know, to talk to somebody who was in better shape than I was

you know, just to find out where their heads were and what they were thinking. Actually the upshot of that is not many of them thought very deeply. They seemed to have learned to do it in a more natural way. It wasn't like a study subject but simply that they started doing it when they were young. They'd learn from each other. It's a good way to learn but it just put me in a different light because I had a reputation among Woody's band as being too generated by thought and understanding. Like they felt like it was demeaning to jazz to intellectualize about it you know. But they were wrong.

MR: Oh interesting. Yeah. Because they were using mostly their ears and so I can sort of picture how they might have listened to you and perhaps they were a little jealous or they just were somewhat threatened by the fact that you had this knowledge.

CC: Were the other band members threatened by the fact that you had this knowledge of the music and intellectualized it?

JC: I think it came as a surprise to them because I don't think there were very many people nationwide who were any further along than I was for the age. And I grew up in a family of jazz musicians so that I was used to thinking about it. It was not a — you know go to a jam session kind of thing and learn by listening. But you listen but you also have, you had to have some information behind it so you could move faster. You could improve more quickly.

MR: So you left Woody Herman and then you ended up with Stan Kenton.

JC: Yeah.

MR: Stan Kenton's band musically was quite different, wasn't it?

JC: Oh yeah. Well actually a lot of both bands' music were less than what I was used to because with the people that I grew up with were members of the same band — we would all be writing charts for the band and learning from each other and most of the people who were on Woody's band or Stan's band didn't have that kind of a background. They were sort of winging it, and succeeding, but I was considered to be kind of an over-intellectualized musician if you want to think of it that way. But they appreciated me, they just didn't — I couldn't converse with them the same way I could with my father or my brother or my mother or even other musicians. And I had a couple of good teachers, two back them. Santy Runion was one of them and another one was named Junie Ferrell. And they were very good teachers, I didn't pick them, my parents picked them for me because they knew that I could learn something from them and indeed I did.

MR: Did you get tired of life on the road riding on a bus etcetera?

JC: Rather quickly I got tired of life on the road. No I didn't — it was maybe interesting to me for the first couple of weeks. And after that it was just, "Where are we going now?" You know. "What time will we have to be there?" I mean it was more — I no longer was

looking forward to being traveling. And I did get to go to Europe with Woody's band so there was that you know. It was that kind of travel that interested me.

MR: Were you married by then?

JC: No.

MR: And I wonder —

JC: I wasn't married until several years after the Woody Herman experience. And my wife at the time was married to one of the trumpet players in the band, who became a very good friend of mine. I worked with him a lot before he died, and we shared a lot of the same things in our love of music.

MR: Did you start looking for another way to make a life in music? To make a career? Like what can I do besides ride a bus?

JC: You mean like teaching?

MR: Correct, yes.

JC: Right. No, I got tired of the road life very quickly. It just took a month or two and I was ready to forget about playing on the road. And if you forget about playing on the road you really need to forget about playing with big name bands because what they're going to do is go on the road. And so that was a stopping point for me. I couldn't stand the idea of living the rest of my life traveling and checking into hotels and motels you know. That life didn't appeal to me. I like music and obviously another part of the problem was that those groups never came up to my expectations. My parents were ahead of us and my brother, my older brother was like a comrade in arms kind of thing. We both felt the same way about everything. But it was a good learning situation because it was around me all the time. It would become a topic over supper, you know what I mean? Vacation — and lot of the vacations we took when I was younger were places where my father was playing with a band during the summer. So it was — we got used to the life.

MR: I see. When you — I'm going to fast forward and you went to the University of Tennessee and can you tell me how that jazz program came to be and was it hard to convince the other music faculty?

JC: Well by then I had already taught in other places and I kind of knew what the other side was thinking. The classical musicians — some of them were very open minded, some of them were not, but as far as I was concerned I wasn't that concerned about it because if I was to do what I was going to do I wasn't going to be trying to get along with them that much. And I did always get along with them in a personal way but in a musical way that didn't mean that much to me.

MR: I know Don Menza talked about going to — when he was in college he went to the same school I went to but he was a few years ahead of me, but they had signs in the practice room "No Jazz Playing."

JC: Oh my.

MR: This would have been the early 1960s.

JC: Oh well that's all right, that's how long it's been taking. No that's — well you know why that happens, one is that they're jealous, you know, a non jazz musician wonders, you know, just what it's like to be able to sit and make music and do it all the time. And then there's a problem of noise, I mean the volume level at which we played, especially if there were more than one of us, if there were five or six of us all playing at once it was a problem for the students to practice in the practice rooms under the circumstances, but it wasn't a big problem, you know. We were always ready to meet it and solve it some other way, you know, have the session at our home or at a club where we knew that they liked to have people sit in, that sort of thing. But it didn't all have to take place in the university.

MR: I see. And also is it somewhat easier for a jazz musician to make a few dollars than it is for a classical musician. Like a jazz musician can go out and play a dance or, you know, play in a combo in a club, where classical musicians have to be in an orchestra or something like that to make any money.

CC: Do you think that the classical musician might have been jealous of the fact that the jazz musicians could make money more easily?

JC: Absolutely. And to make matters even worse, some of us, including myself also got money playing in symphony orchestras you know. So there was no place that they were safe. And they knew that I was having a happier life.

MR: You had a happier life.

JC: Oh yeah.

MR: That's —

JC: Yeah. No, if you love the music then you've got a happy life there because there are a lot of musicians that are not jazz musicians that don't have nearly as much fun. They have some but not as much as a jazz musician has. There's not as much of an opportunity to express yourself in a very personal sort of way. It's — I see you've got one of my books.

MR: I do. I have a few of your books. And I'm amazed and happy when I read through this book, how well it holds up. You know? Some of the things you say, like you were talking about swing and how it works and how it doesn't work, and it's very interesting to think that you wrote this back in 1964 and it still works.

JC: Well thank you.

MR: When you got a new student, a new saxophone student, can you describe what you did during their first lesson to figure out how to help them?

JC: The first lesson, on my first lesson?

MR: No your first lesson with a new student.

JC: With a student.

MR: Correct.

JC: You're wondering how I would handle it?

MR: I wondered what would be the first thing that you would try to do. Would you listen to them play?

JC: I wouldn't — for starters I wasn't trying to talk them into studying jazz. Okay? If they did, fine. If they didn't it was okay too. Because I also play classical music and I play the other woodwinds — oboe, flute, clarinet, bassoon — and so, and I had that experience behind me. So really there were no surprises. I mean a student could come in, he could be a bad student but he was going to be bad at anything. You know what I mean? It didn't matter what his focus was, he either could play or he couldn't at that point anyway, and then it was up to me to try to figure out how to untangle it for him so he could succeed in the music he did love, the one he liked the most. But I didn't try to convince them that they ought to be a jazz musician or that they should avoid jazz. I figured that as individuals they made that decision a long time before they came to me. So I accept wherever they are. If they said I only want to study classical music I was okay with that. Or if they said I only want to study jazz I was okay with that. You know it didn't matter to me. I just needed to know the student, what their interests and abilities were and then I'd know how to proceed with them. And I always waited to see how they were reacting to things. You know? So I could follow their line of curiosity and answer the questions as best as I could but even at times when they didn't bring it up but I knew they should go there or might have.

MR: So you taught saxophone, classical saxophone music as well.

JC: Yeah. Right. I didn't do it nearly as much and I didn't enjoy it as much, but there were things about it that I could get hold of that I could hang on to that weren't so bad you know. But I just felt like my father was a saxophonist and I just felt like there was a certain tie between saxophone and jazz music. And I liked that tie. The saxophone to me is sort of like the human voice. You know? It's a personal kind of sound that you make on it. I mean it's easier to tell who a saxophone player is that you're listening to on a record by the way they play and by the sound they make. I don't think I could do that with a classical saxophonist but you can hear the influences in a jazz player. He's using what he has heard. Whereas a classical musician is using what they've read you know, and that's the difference. But there's nothing wrong — I don't mean to sound like I'm putting down classical music. I would never think of doing such a thing. I might point out that the literature for jazz — I'm sorry — the literature for saxophone is not where it ought to be that much I know. I've studied classical saxophone as well and the music that

you have to work on is not up to the standard of say what you would learn if you were playing clarinet or flute. You know the literature isn't as strong.

MR: And most of it is quite modern.

JC: Right.

MR: Because the saxophone was not around for all those years.

JC: Right, right. Exactly. And I don't think you can survive playing something that was originally written for clarinet or bass clarinet or flute and oboe. You know. I play all of the woodwinds. I've studied all of the woodwinds. I was a woodwind major on my doctorate degree which involved that, you know, that I could make a difference between say a student that wanted to learn to play jazz and a student that wanted to learn to play classical music. They're different. And you can't treat them all the same way. But what's on their minds? What do they like? What are they interested in? Who are they emulating, you know? And then give them, get them there as best as you can but it isn't — I'm not trying to sell them down the river with jazz music you know. If they're interested in it fine. If they're not I'm not going to force them.

MR: I'm going to guess that during all this teaching you kept playing gigs and I had a little note here about you playing gigs in Miami Beach?

JC: Right. What about Miami Beach?

MR: It looks like you played with a real variety of people, in fact you and I have something in common, we both shared the stage with Tiny Tim.

JC: Oh I see what you mean. Yeah. Right. No when I was in Miami, that was where ninety percent of my playing engagements were, playing shows, different shows in different places. It was a very busy kind of life, and a good paying one. And I didn't care much for it musically you know, but I wasn't doing it for the music alone.

MR: And who was the biggest name that you recall playing with at Miami Beach? Someone really well known?

JC: Frank Sinatra.

MR: Hmm. He's pretty well known.

JC: Oh yeah, right. I mean there were others but they wouldn't — many others — but — well if you name some I could tell you whether or not I played with them.

MR: Was Frank Sinatra easily annoyed?

JC: Was he what?

MR: Was he easily annoyed? Did he get angry at all?

JC: Well not the Frank I knew. The Frank that I knew was instructive, in other words where he'd come in to work with the band, prepare for a show, he was ready to teach them to do it. He wasn't a hard boiled kind of person that didn't like, you know the musicians if they

couldn't do it, that sort of thing. He was actually very easy for me to know. We got along very well.

MR: I'm happy to hear that. You must have been a very good sight reader to play these shows?

JC: Right. Well that was learned both in classical music and in jazz music, but I was used to reading. It's unquestionable that I was more interested in improvising and that sort of thing, but I wrote a lot of music, and reading music was a part of my life that I couldn't ignore.

MR: There's a note I have here about the Huntsville Prison Band.

JC: You had a what?

MR: The Huntsville Prison Band.

JC: Oh yeah.

MR: Were you a member of the Huntsville Prison Band?

JC: I was a teacher.

MR: Okay. See I had to raise my hand because that was a joke.

JC: No I taught at both the men's and women's institutions there in Florida — I mean sorry, in Texas. And that was a very rewarding experience too because a lot of those people made something out of their lives after they got out, after they were released and I knew I had something to do with that. I was ready to help them get on the path. And you know it's very satisfying to see them succeeding in something they couldn't succeed in before, because of what I taught them. It gives you the strength to keep doing it.

MR: That's pretty profound. There's something about music that you can learn a lot more just besides the music, I guess discipline and really loving something is worth a lot.

JC: Well yeah, I think it's always good to learn as much as you can, and that means to learn other styles than one. I mean classical music was very close to me, and jazz was even closer to me, but even if I had to play a commercial job I was happy to bend a little to meet their way of doing things. I didn't want to stand out as somebody who is rebellious toward the music that was being played. There was no point in that. And sometimes I bumped into some very thoughtful personalities in playing with bands that were playing commercial music you know. They're everywhere.

MR: Your books were one of the first on the market. Did you have — how did you test them out? Did you try some of your ideas out with your students before you actually put them in a book?

JC: Mostly I looked backward to how I learned. And I was blessed with a couple of very good teachers: Junie Ferrell and Santy Runion and they were both not only teaching me things but open to what I wanted to learn. And so it gave me a good attitude about studying, about practicing, you labor for these things, get them to come to pass.

MR: Did you have trouble finding a publisher for your books? Especially in the beginning.

JC: They came to me.

MR: They came to you!

JC: Right. What happens in a lot of cases I'm sure, is that based on what you might have written for a master's thesis gets their attention. Or you write an article for a jazz magazine or something and the right person reads it and feels like hey, we could use him. And of course my students are the best advertising of all because if they're out there and they're making it and the players they are playing with are appreciating them, they want to know. How did you learn? Where did you go? And so that ends up feeding itself.

MR: I wonder if you're amazed by the fact that jazz education is now a huge business in America?

JC: Right. That was natural. Jazz is more of an everybody kind of music, you know? Including classical. I mean jazz musicians generally know quite a bit about classical music now. They may know about the commercial side of the music, the dance bands kind of thing. They're not all hard boiled jazz musicians that won't look to the right or to the left anymore. They do a lot of studio work, recording, which causes them to need to have the jazz background but they're not really there to play jazz, you know what I mean? They're not about to be an improvising musician when they come into the record date, they just need to be stylistically versatile. And we got into that too when we were playing shows. When you play musical shows there are all kinds of things. There might be a gymnast one time and a vocalist another, a dancer on another, and this kind of thing. And the same thing with their backgrounds, there are all different kinds of people who come in on shows. And when you work a lot of shows, which I did, then you're getting inside their minds as they work with you, you know you find out what they know, what they don't know, but you learn a lot yourself.

MR: I'll bet your son was not very old when he learned what the word gig meant.

JC: He didn't know what the word "gig" meant?

MR: No I bet he learned it very early because Dad has another gig tonight.

JC: Oh.

MR: Because I know my kids was like, "Oh Dad do you have another gig tonight? When are you going to be home?"

JC: Right.

MR: Do you still have — you know most musicians get a sort of body clock where they're late night people and not so much early morning people. Are you still a late night person?

JC: Am I still a night person?

MR: A late night person, yeah.

JC: A late night person? Not really. I mean yes I have needed to do it from time to time because some engagements like in Miami Beach, you're liable to still be there at 1:30 or

2:00 in the morning playing shows you know. And even beyond that, there are all kinds of jobs that I've worked that were not necessarily what I wanted to do every day, every night, but they were there, I worked them you know. I enjoy playing different kinds of engagements.

MR: Okay. I've got just two more questions for you today and I wondered, when you started writing arrangements for bands, was it a thrill to hear it for the first time?

JC: Oh sure. Sure. I think it's probably what most arrangers or composers, that's what they go for is they want to hear their music being played, especially if it comes out good you know. If it doesn't, I don't know what they would do, I guess they'd stop writing.

MR: Yes it's easier to fix things now with the computer programs, but back then you were using a pencil and a score pad and you sort of had to trust your ear that you were doing it right.

JC: That's right. That's right. Well I'm thinking that even if I did use modern methods I still would want to know the old method, the natural way to do it. I wouldn't say that the new outmodes the old, you know. It just adds to it in a different way of approaching things.

MR: And am I correct that you went on a tour of the Middle East with the Indiana University group?

JC: Right. Yes.

MR: That must have been quite an amazing experience for a young man. Or how old were you?

JC: Hum?

MR: How old were you when you went to the Middle East?

JC: Oh yeah.

MR: And was Randy Brecker on board for that one?

JC: Oh yeah. Yeah Randy was a heavily featured person in the band. It was obvious that he was going to be a good player you know. But no he wasn't the only one you know there were several people in the band he was in that were worth going to listen to, no question about it.

MR: I have a note here that he got a nickname called "The Lion of Aleppo?"

JC: Right. Well that came — "The Lion of Aleppo" was a term that was used by the people of one of those countries that we visited. It was their way of talking about somebody who was important. "The Lion of Aleppo" just became sort of a cliche and so it was natural that when you had a soloist that was succeeding no matter where you went they were like "The Lion of Aleppo" they could get through to anybody with their playing.

MR: You recorded a number of LPs or CDs over the years and I wonder if you ever put them on to listen to yourself?

JC: No. Sorry.

MR: That's okay. Most musicians respond with the same answer. Well this has really been a joy for me, and I appreciate you taking your time today.

JC: Right. And I enjoyed talking to you.

MR: I'm going to close with something you wrote in the beginning of this book and this is the very first thing that you wrote. And it said, "The training, care and feeding of the jazz musician is something which many of us ought to be more concerned. For jazz is the significant and vital musical language truly of our time. Its value has increased with the years as it developed beyond its humble beginnings to become a sophisticated art form which speaks an international world-wide language."

JC: That sounds great. I'd like to use that in a book sometime.

MR: Well I'm going to give you permission. You know it was prescient at the time but it's still profound, Mr. Coker, so as I said, thank you for your time, and thank Curt, your son, for helping us out here. And I appreciate it very much.

JC: Okay. I enjoyed it and I enjoyed meeting you.

MR: Likewise. We'll do a virtual handshake.

JC: All right.

MR: All right there you go. Thank you very much.

JC: You bet.